reforms (Wallander 2000; Ikenberry 2011b). The aftermath of World War II, for instance, spurred the creation of the multilateral institutions that underpin today's liberal order, while the financial crises of the late 2000s pushed organizations like the IMF to rethink their roles in the global economy. In these moments, a shared sense of urgency and external pressure from member states, civil society, and private actors often drive IOs to implement rapid and meaningful changes. Crises not only galvanize political will but also create the conditions for resource mobilization and mandate expansion.

Populist takeovers, especially in hegemonic powers like the United States or across a critical mass of member states, can rise to the level of such a crisis. The threat that populists pose to IOs through funding cuts, public delegitimization, or outright withdrawal can cripple institutional operations and destabilize global governance. The scale and nature of IOs' responses tend to correspond to the perceived severity of the populist challenge. When threats are localized or deemed minor, IOs often employ incremental strategies like appeasement or sidelining, making small but cumulative adjustments to their operations and culture over time (Carnegie and Clark 2023). Such small and targeted changes are unlikely to have long-term repercussions for perceptions of legitimacy and fairness. However, when populist influence becomes widespread or entrenched, IOs may pursue more sweeping reforms, such as altering institutional rules or redistributing power within the organization.

That said, the effectiveness of these strategies diminishes as populism grows in prevalence. When populist-led states constitute a significant portion of an IO's membership, sidelining becomes impractical—replacing the contributions of multiple key members simultaneously is a difficult task. Similarly, appeasement becomes untenable when too many concessions are required, particularly if they involve zero-sum trade-offs like redistributing voting shares or financial benefits. For instance, the EU has struggled to appease euro-skeptic parties through budgetary adjustments as their influence within the bloc has grown (Sadeh, Raskin, and Rubinson 2022).

Moreover, appeasement and sidelining strategies face limitations when used frequently or visibly. Repeated secrecy measures can undermine public trust, while efforts to engage broader audiences may encounter diminishing returns as these audiences grow more diverse and diffuse.